The Ballot or the Bullet

Malcolm X · Cleveland, OH (April 3, 1964) & Detroit (April 12, 1964) · excerpts

Source: Reprinted in Malcolm X Speaks: Selected Speeches and Statements (ed. George Breitman, 1965).

Three weeks after breaking with the Nation of Islam, Malcolm X delivered this speech in Cleveland and again in Detroit. He framed 1964 as a watershed election year and argued that Black Americans had to use either the ballot or, failing that, the bullet — the right of self-defense. The speech marked Malcolm's pivot from Nation-of-Islam separatism toward broader Black nationalism and the international human-rights frame he would develop in the months before his assassination in February 1965.

Connect: Malcolm X's rejection of nonviolence echoes David Walker's 1829 Appeal (Class 19) — both Black leaders argued for self-defense. What continues, and what has changed?

Key Passages

The diagnosis

> I'm not a politician, not even a student of politics; in fact, I'm not a student of much of anything. I'm not a Democrat. I'm not a Republican, and I don't even consider myself an American. … No, I'm not an American. I'm one of the 22 million Black people who are the victims of Americanism.

Ballot or bullet

> 1964 threatens to be the most explosive year America has ever witnessed. … It's the year when all of the white political crooks will be right back in your and my community … trying to bamboozle you and me. … It'll be the ballot or it'll be the bullet.

On self-defense

> I don't even call it violence when it's self-defense, I call it intelligence.

On nonviolence

> Concerning nonviolence: it is criminal to teach a man not to defend himself when he is the constant victim of brutal attacks.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — compare branches of the CRM: Identify ONE significant similarity AND ONE difference between Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. in 1964.

2. What does Malcolm X mean by saying he is 'not an American'?

3. How did Malcolm's views shift in the year between this speech and his assassination?